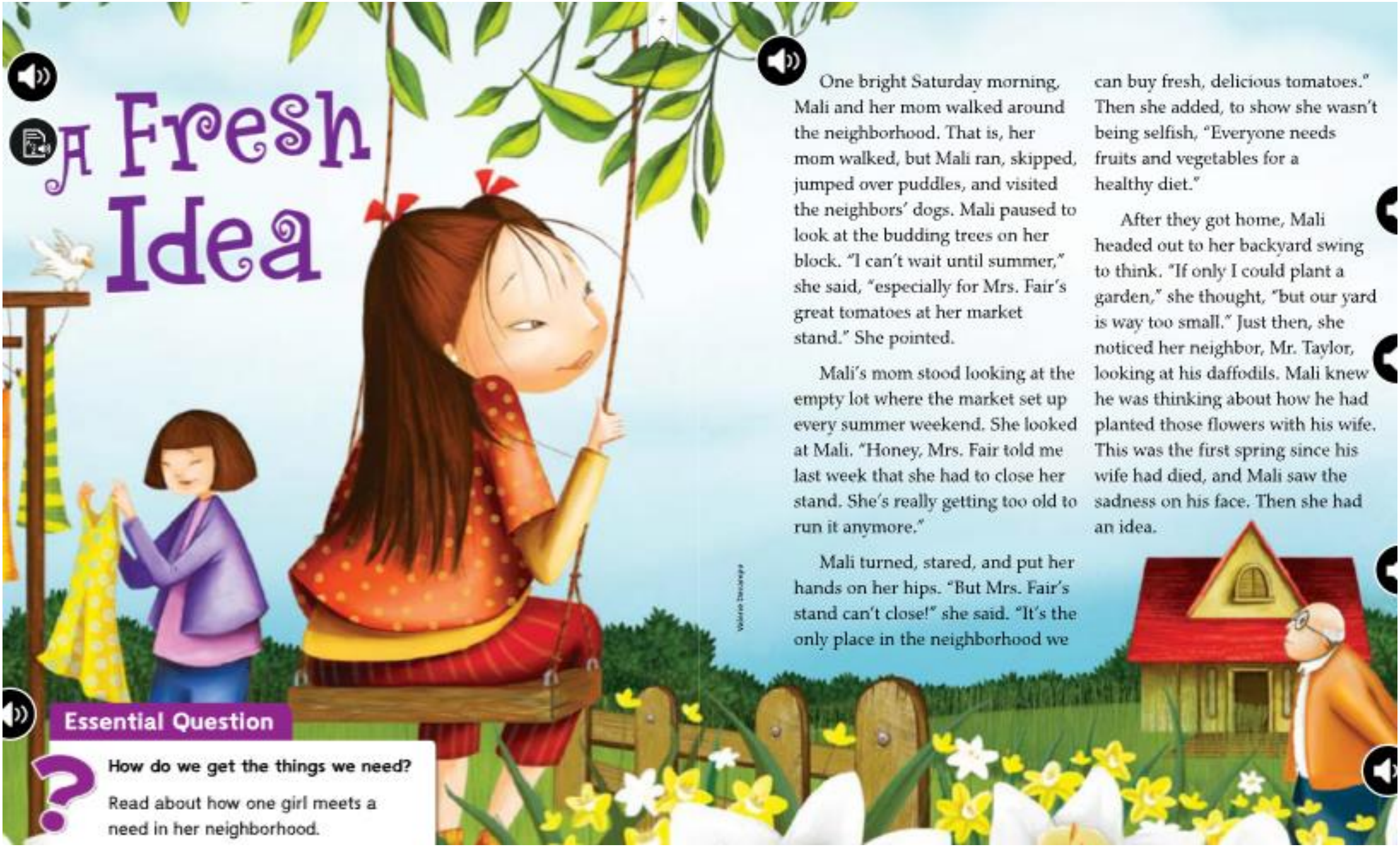
A Fresh Idea



Essential Question

How do we get the things we need?

Read about how one girl meets a need in her neighborhood.

One bright Saturday morning, Mali and her mom walked around the neighborhood. That is, her mom walked, but Mali ran, skipped, jumped over puddles, and visited the neighbors' dogs. Mali paused to look at the budding trees on her block. "I can't wait until summer," she said, "especially for Mrs. Fair's great tomatoes at her market stand." She pointed.

Mali's mom stood looking at the empty lot where the market set up every summer weekend. She looked at Mali. "Honey, Mrs. Fair told me last week that she had to close her stand. She's really getting too old to run it anymore."

Mali turned, stared, and put her hands on her hips. "But Mrs. Fair's stand can't close!" she said. "It's the only place in the neighborhood we can buy fresh, delicious tomatoes." Then she added, to show she wasn't being selfish, "Everyone needs fruits and vegetables for a healthy diet."

After they got home, Mali headed out to her backyard swing to think. "If only I could plant a garden," she thought, "but our yard is way too small." Just then, she noticed her neighbor, Mr. Taylor, looking at his daffodils. Mali knew he was thinking about how he had planted those flowers with his wife. This was the first spring since his wife had died, and Mali saw the sadness on his face. Then she had an idea.

Mali cleared her throat, and Mr. Taylor looked up. Mali decided to walk over to the fence. "Hi, Mr. Taylor," she said. He waved, and turned away. "Wait!" Mali cried. Taking a **risk** while she still felt brave, she rushed to gather her thoughts: "Mr. Taylor, Mrs. Fair isn't doing her tomato stand anymore because she's getting old. So I'd like to grow tomatoes. I don't want to get in the way of your flowers, though. I mean, I really like tomatoes."

Suddenly, Mr. Taylor smiled. "Mali, I'm not sure what you're talking about, but you've made me smile. Reasons to smile have been **scarce** lately. What do you want to do?"

As Mr. Taylor listened, an idea came to him. "I still need a place to plant my flowers, but there's room for tomatoes. How about I make you a **loan?** I'll let you use a plot of land in my yard. I'll help you, and when your garden starts to **prosper,** you can repay me with a few tomatoes."

Mali and Mr. Taylor shook hands on this deal. "But first," Mr. Taylor said, "you'll have to make an investment by buying some tomato plants at the nursery."

Mali thought. "Well, I have some **savings** from my allowance, and I was saving to buy a computer game." She paused. "But I'd rather have tomatoes, so let's start right away!"

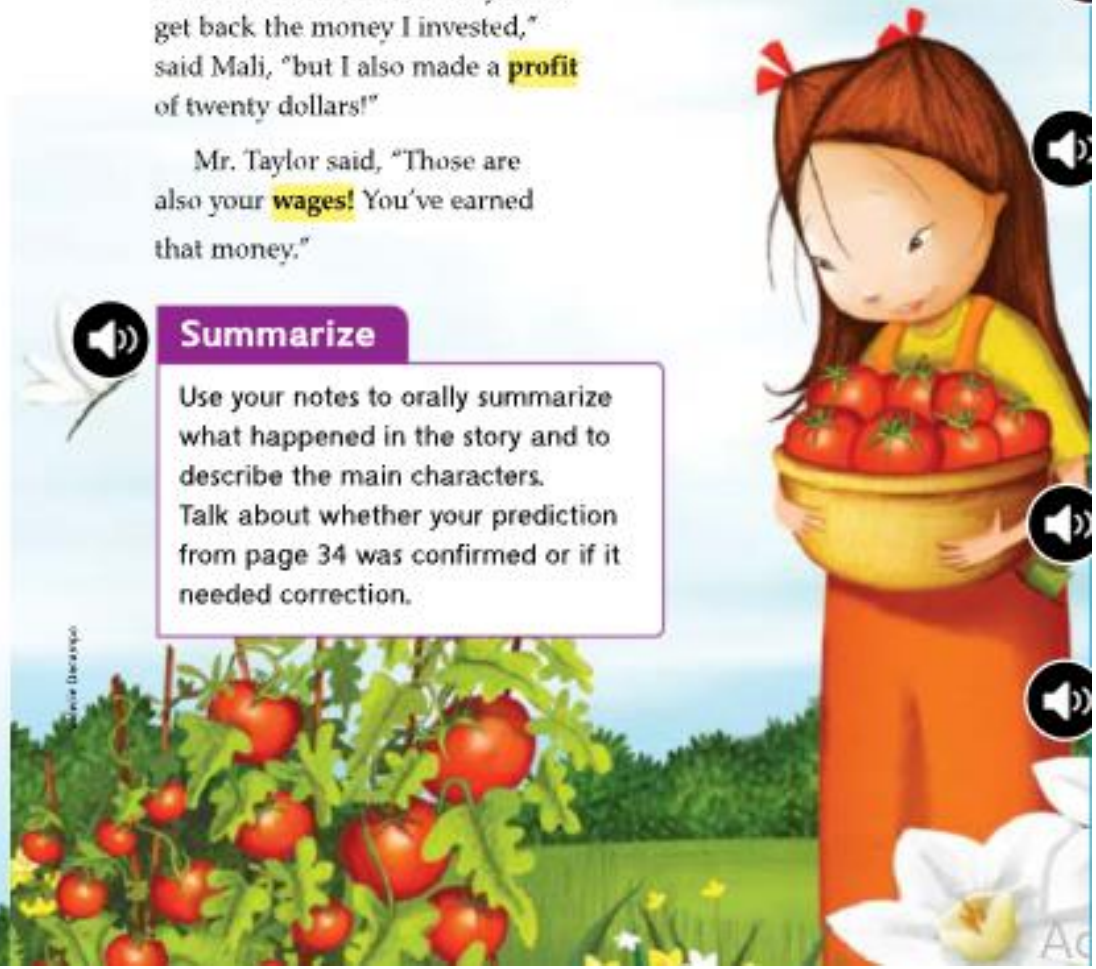
The next day, Mali bought all the tomato plants she could **afford.** Mr. Taylor taught Mali how to prepare the soil and place the plants. Finally, Mali placed stakes as supports in the ground to help hold the plants up. Mr. Taylor explained, "Once the tomatoes come, the heavy fruit makes the branches bend." Then all they could do was water, pull weeds, and wait.



When the fruit ripened, there were more juicy, red tomatoes than even Mali could have imagined. "There is no way I can eat all these," she realized. On Saturday, Mali and Mr. Taylor carried several crates of ripe tomatoes to the market, and by the day's end they had sold them all. "Not only did I get back the money I invested," said Mali, "but I also made a **profit** of twenty dollars!"

Mr. Taylor said, "Those are also your **wages!** You've earned that money."

Mali beamed and said, "Mr. Taylor, maybe you could sell some of your flowers, and we could run a market stand together!" Mr. Taylor, picturing a garden of zinnias and marigolds, was already looking forward to next summer.



Summarize

Use your notes to orally summarize what happened in the story and to describe the main characters. Talk about whether your prediction from page 34 was confirmed or if it needed correction.